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THE BRAND VOICE PLAYBOOK

Build a brand voice document from scratch.

By MK Parrish

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INTRO: WHY MOST BRANDS SOUND LIKE A GROUP PROJECT

Read ten company About pages back to back and you'll feel it — the same warmed-over confidence, the same "we're on a mission to revolutionize," the same nobody-actually-talks-like-this sheen. Most brands don't have a voice. They have a committee average. Three people wrote it, four more sanded the edges off, and what's left is the verbal equivalent of beige carpet.

A real brand voice is a decision. It's the difference between a company that sounds like a company and one that sounds like a person you'd want to know. And it doesn't come from inspiration — it comes from a document. A specific, opinionated, written-down set of rules that anyone on the team can follow to sound like one consistent human.

This playbook builds that document from scratch. We'll define the voice foundation, map your tone across situations, build do/don't vocabulary lists, and then I'll walk you through a complete worked example for an invented company so you can see every piece assembled. By the end you'll have a template you can fill in for any brand — yours or a client's.

This is the premium, roll-up-your-sleeves one. Have a notebook or a doc open. We're building something you'll actually use.

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Brand voice isn't decoration you add at the end. It's a decision you make at the start about who you are when you open your mouth.

02

CHAPTER ONE: VOICE VS. TONE (GET THIS RIGHT OR NOTHING WORKS)

People use these interchangeably. They're not the same, and confusing them is why most voice work falls apart.

Voice is constant. Tone is contextual.

Your voice is your brand's personality — fixed, recognizable, the same whether you're announcing a launch or apologizing for an outage. A person doesn't get a new personality every morning. Neither does a brand.

Tone is how that voice flexes to fit the moment. A confident, warm brand is still confident and warm in an error message — but the tone dials down the playfulness and up the reassurance. Same voice, adjusted tone.

The analogy: voice is the instrument; tone is what you play on it. A cello is always a cello. It can play a funeral or a flirtation. Your brand should be that recognizable and that flexible at once.

If you only define voice, your team won't know how to handle a refund email. If you only define tone case-by-case, you'll drift into a different personality every week. The document we're building covers both.

03

CHAPTER TWO: THE VOICE FOUNDATION FRAMEWORK

Before vocabulary, before tone, you decide who the brand *is*. Four components. Answer each in writing — vague answers here poison everything downstream.

1. The Voice in One Sentence

Force the whole personality into a single line. "We sound like a sharp, generous mentor who's seen it all and roots for you anyway." If you can't write the sentence, you don't know the voice yet. Keep drafting until it's true.

2. The Three-to-Five Traits

Pick a handful of personality traits — and crucially, define each by what it *means* and what it *doesn't* mean. "Confident" is useless alone. "Confident — we state things plainly without hedging; this does NOT mean arrogant or dismissive" is usable. The "doesn't mean" clause is where you prevent the trait from being misread into something off-brand.

3. The Brand's Beliefs

What does this brand think is true that others in its space won't say? Voice without conviction is just style. The beliefs give your writers something to *stand on*, not just a way to sound. List three to five.

4. The Human Comparison

Finish the sentence: "If our brand were a person, it would be ___ — but not ___." ("A favorite professor who makes hard things click — but not a stuffy academic." "Your most honest friend — but not the one who's mean and calls it honesty.") This gives writers an instant gut-check.

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*A trait without a "doesn't mean" clause is a trait waiting to be misinterpreted.
Define your voice by its borders, not just its center.*

04

CHAPTER THREE: TONE SPECTRUM MAPPING

Voice is set. Now map how it flexes. A tone spectrum is a set of sliders your brand moves along depending on the situation.

Define your brand's range on four spectrums. For each, mark where your *default* sits, then note how it shifts in specific contexts.

SPECTRUM	ONE END	OTHER END
Formal ↔ Casual	Boardroom	Group chat
Serious ↔ Playful	Solemn	Winking
Reserved ↔ Bold	Understated	Declarative
Warm ↔ Matter-of-fact	Arm around shoulder	Just the facts

Now map tone to situations. This is the table that saves your team:

SITUATION	WHERE THE SLIDERS MOVE
Marketing / launch copy	Bolder, more playful, full warmth
Onboarding & education	Warm, slightly more formal, patient
Error & outage messages	Serious, matter-of-fact, still warm; never playful
Billing & legal	Formal, clear, reassuring; zero cleverness
Customer support replies	Warm, casual, bold enough to take ownership
Bad news / apologies	Serious, plain, humble; cut all marketing language

The rule that holds it together: **the voice never changes, only the tone.** A playful brand doesn't crack jokes during an outage — but it's still recognizably itself, just turned to its serious, warm setting.

05

CHAPTER FOUR: DO/DON'T VOCABULARY LISTS

This is the most-used page in any voice doc, because it's the most actionable. You're building a working dictionary: words and phrases that are on-brand, and ones that are banned.

Build four lists.

1. Words We Use. The vocabulary that sounds like you. Verbs especially — voice lives in verbs. ("Build, sharpen, decide, cut, earn.")

2. Words We Avoid. The dead phrases and off-brand words. Be specific and a little ruthless. ("Synergy, leverage, robust, seamless, revolutionary, passionate, journey, unlock, game-changer.")

3. How We Say Common Things. Take recurring messages and write the on-brand version. This is where consistency actually happens:

INSTEAD OF	WE SAY
"We apologize for any inconvenience."	"That's on us. Here's how we're fixing it."
"Please don't hesitate to reach out."	"Questions? Just ask — we read every message."
"We're excited to announce..."	"It's here. Here's why it matters to you."
"Our innovative solution..."	(describe what it actually does)

4. Grammar & Mechanics Calls. The small consistency decisions: contractions yes or no (almost always yes — they're how humans talk), Oxford comma, sentence-case or title-case headers, emoji policy, exclamation-point budget. Boring, essential, and the thing teams fight about forever if it isn't written down.

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A brand voice document is only as strong as its examples. "Be friendly" is a wish. A swap table is a tool.

CHAPTER FIVE: A COMPLETE WORKED EXAMPLE — TIDEWATER & CO.

Theory's done. Here's the whole document, filled in for a company I made up so you can see every piece working together. **Tidewater & Co.** is a (fictional) financial planning firm for self-employed creatives — freelancers, artists, and founders who are great at their craft and terrified of their own taxes.

The Voice Foundation

Voice in one sentence: Tidewater sounds like the financially fluent friend who explains money without making you feel stupid — calm, candid, quietly funny, always on your side.

Traits:

- **Plainspoken** — we explain money in language a human uses. This does NOT mean dumbed-down or condescending.
- **Reassuring** — we lower the reader's blood pressure. This does NOT mean falsely cheerful or dismissive of real fear.
- **Candid** — we tell the truth about money, including the uncomfortable parts. This does NOT mean blunt to the point of cold.
- **Quietly witty** — a dry line where it earns its place. This does NOT mean jokey, meme-y, or unserious about people's livelihoods.

Beliefs:

- Financial anxiety usually comes from confusion, not numbers. Clarity is the actual product.
- Creative people aren't "bad with money." They were handed money advice written for salaried 9-to-5s and told they failed it.
- Shame is the enemy. Nobody made a good financial decision while being lectured.

Human comparison: Tidewater is the friend who's a CPA and actually fun at dinner — but NOT the smug finance bro, and NOT the doom-and-gloom advisor who makes you want to never open a bank statement again.

The Tone Spectrum

Default sliders: leaning casual, mostly serious with room for dry wit, bold in our convictions, high warmth.

SITUATION	TONE SHIFT
Website / marketing	Warmest and boldest; wit allowed; lead with relief
Educational content	Patient, plainspoken, wit dialed down, zero condescension
Account/tax reminders	Calm, clear, matter-of-fact, reassuring; no nagging
When the client owes money / bad news	Serious, candid, shame-free, fully warm; no jokes

Vocabulary

Words we use: clarity, breathing room, plan, real numbers, set up, sort out, on your side, no shame, here's the deal.

Words we avoid: wealth journey, financial freedom (overused), leverage, robust, holistic solutions, "as per," synergize, hustle, grind.

How we say common things:

INSTEAD OF	TIDEWATER SAYS
"Maximize your tax efficiency."	"Keep more of what you earned. Legally, obviously."
"We offer comprehensive financial solutions."	"We help you figure out what to do with your money — and stop dreading April."
"You have failed to submit required documentation."	"We're still missing a couple things to file for you. Two-minute fix — here's what we need."
"Per our records, your balance is past due."	"Heads up: this one's overdue. No judgment — let's just get it sorted. Here are your options."

Mechanics: Contractions, always. Oxford comma, yes. Sentence-case headers. Emoji: rarely, and never in anything money-serious. Exclamation points: one per page, max — we're calm, not caffeinated.

Voice in Action — Before & After

A real snippet, written the generic way and the Tidewater way.

Before (generic):

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"At Tidewater & Co., we are passionate about empowering creative entrepreneurs to achieve financial freedom through our innovative, holistic suite of planning solutions."

After (on-brand):

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"You're great at the thing you do. You are, by your own admission, a disaster at the money part. That's fine — that's literally our job. We'll set up a plan in plain English, handle the parts that make you panic, and make tax season a non-event. No shame, no jargon, no lectures."

Same company. One of them you'd hire.

CHAPTER SIX: BUILDING, MAINTAINING, AND DEFENDING THE DOC

You have the framework and a model to copy. Three notes on making it last.

Keep it to one usable document. A 40-page brand bible nobody opens is worthless. The version people actually use is tight: the one-sentence voice, the traits with their "doesn't mean" clauses, the tone table, the swap lists, the mechanics calls. If it doesn't fit in something a new hire can absorb in fifteen minutes, cut it down.

Lead with examples, always. Every rule needs a before/after or a swap. Teams don't follow principles; they follow patterns. The example is the rule.

Defend it from the committee. The moment a voice succeeds, people will want to soften it — add a hedge, remove a stance, make it "a little more professional." That's the beige carpet creeping back in. The whole value of the document is that it lets you say "that's off-voice" and point to the page. A voice with no borders isn't a voice. It's a vibe, and vibes don't survive contact with a busy team.

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The goal isn't a beautiful document. It's a brand that sounds like one specific, recognizable person no matter who's holding the keyboard. The document is just how you keep your promise to sound like yourself.

08

KEEP GOING

You now have everything you need to build a voice from scratch — and a worked example to model.

If you're a solo operator and the brand you most need to voice is *you*, start with **Write Yourself Into the Room** — the personal-brand companion to this playbook, with positioning frameworks and bio templates.

And if you're a founder or creative whose own identity is still mid-rewrite — voice is hard to build on shifting ground — **The Reinvention Workbook** does that deeper work.

Find more, and inquire about done-for-you voice work, at mkparrish.com.

Most brands settle for sounding like everyone. You're not going to. You have the document now.

— MK Parrish

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